

— FREE RESOURCE

The Decoded Method

How to document the way your business runs without a 200-page manual nobody opens. Three layers, plain English, one page per process. Built to be handed over, not held onto.

Process Register

The spine. One row per process: name, owner, last reviewed.

SOPs • one page each

The how-to layer. Five sections, no more, no fewer.

Improvement Log

The Kaizen layer. Log what broke, what changed, the result.

Why most process documentation fails

Most businesses have their processes in one place: someone's head. When that person is on holiday, or leaves, the process leaves with them. The usual fix, a giant quality manual, fails for the opposite reason: it's too long to maintain, so it goes stale and nobody trusts it.

The Decoded Method is the middle path. ISO 9001 principles without the ISO overhead. A Kaizen improvement habit without the DMAIC ceremony. Lean enough to actually keep up to date.

Three layers, each with a job. Together they make a system you can hand to a new starter and trust them to follow.

Layer 1: The Process Register.

The spine. One row per process: what it's called, who owns it, and when it was last looked at. Often the first time a business has everything it does written down in one place.

DO-PR-001	Discovery Day Delivery	Craig	Clarity	Delivery	active	Jun 2025
TB-PR-004	Order Intake Sync	Sarah	Deliver	Tech	draft	May 2025
DO-PR-007	Monthly Retained Review	Craig	Retained	Admin	review	Jun 2025

- Ref:** a short code, e.g. TB-PR-001
- Owner:** one named person, never "the team"
- Category:** Delivery, Sales, Admin, Finance, Marketing, or Tech
- Status:** active, draft, review, or archived
- Last reviewed:** the month it was last checked

Layer 2: The SOPs.

The how-to layer. One page per process. A hard limit. If it needs more than a page, it's two processes, not one. Five sections, no more, no fewer.

TB-PR-001 · Thread Colour Matching

1. What this process does

One sentence: what it produces and why it exists

2. Trigger

The specific event that starts it (never "when needed")

3. Steps

Numbered, plain English, actionable

4. What good looks like

A measurable outcome, so you know it worked

5. AI skills

Which tools to reach for, and in what order

What this process does: one sentence: what it produces and why it exists

Trigger: the specific event that starts it (never "when needed")

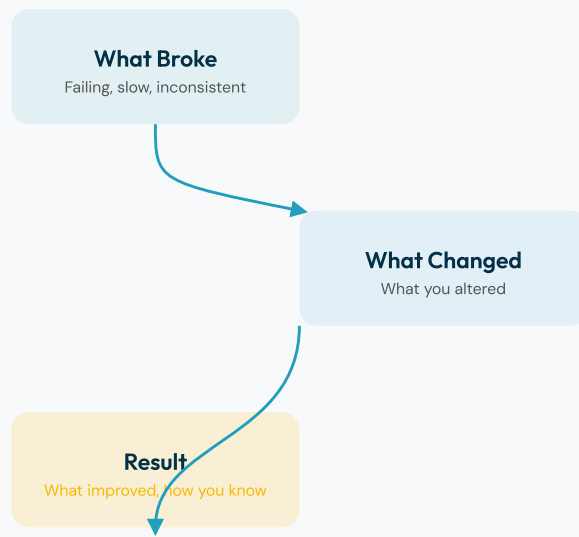
Steps: numbered, plain English, actionable

What good looks like: a measurable outcome, so you know it worked

AI skills: which tools to reach for, and in what order

Layer 3: The Improvement Log.

The Kaizen layer. When something breaks or gets better, you log it in three fields, nothing more. Every entry points back to the process it changed, so the register stays honest over time.



What broke: what was failing, inconsistent, or slow

What changed: what you actually altered

Result: what improved, and how you know

Plain English. If the least experienced person can't follow it without asking, it's still a draft.

One page per process. If it needs more than a page, split it.

Owner on everything. One named person. Not a team.

Reviewed regularly. Quarterly for most; at each milestone for active builds.

Delivery-linked. Every system handed over ships with its process pack. Handover is never verbal-only.

ISO-ready, not ISO-burdened. Maps to ISO 9001 principles, without the certification weight.

What it looks like in practice

Here's the live register we run Decoded Ops on. Twelve processes, each owned, each with a status. This is the same artefact a Clarity engagement produces for a client, usually the first time they've seen their whole operation on one page.

Ref	Process	Status
DO-PR-001	Discovery Day Delivery	active
DO-PR-002	Clarity Audit & Report	active
DO-PR-003	New Client Onboarding	active
DO-PR-004	Proposal Build & Sign-off	active
DO-PR-005	App Requirements Capture	active
DO-PR-006	ERP/eCommerce Integration Scoping	active
DO-PR-007	Monthly Retained Review	active
DO-PR-008	Invoice & Billing Cycle	active
DO-PR-009	Client Handover & Sign-off	draft
DO-PR-010	Process Pack Production	draft
DO-PR-011	LinkedIn Content Publishing	review
DO-PR-012	Sub-contractor Engagement	draft

Want this run across your own operation?

A Clarity engagement builds your Process Register with you, mapping what you actually do, who owns it, and where the gaps are. It's usually the first time it's all written down.

Book a free discovery call →

See what Clarity covers